

BLUE-SPOTTED RIBBONTAIL RAY

Taeniura lymma

Stingrays are notorious for the painful wounds they can inflict with their barbed tail, which can, in exceptional circumstances, be lethal. However, the tropical blue-spotted ribbontail ray, like other stingrays, uses its sting just to defend itself. Much of its time is spent resting motionless on sandy patches among coral, hidden under overhangs. Often only its blue-edged tail gives it away to divers – if disturbed, it will swim away, flapping its two wing-like pectoral fins. The best time to see one is on a rising tide when the stingrays swim inshore to feed on invertebrates in shallow water.

PELVIC FINS >

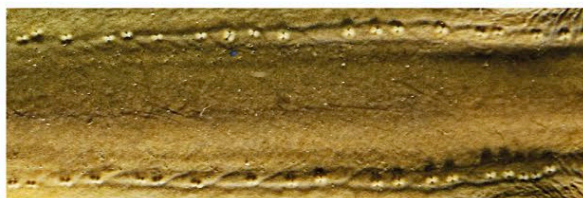
In this female the urogenital opening is visible between the pelvic fins on the underside. After mating, females produce up to seven live young following a few months' to a year's gestation.



✓ TOP HOLE

Water is drawn in through two spiracles on top of the head behind the eyes, and leaves through gill slits on the underside.

The elevated position of the spiracles helps prevent sand getting in.



SIZE 70–90 cm (28–35 in), including tail
HABITAT Sandy patches in coral reefs
DISTRIBUTION Indian Ocean, W. Pacific
DIET Molluscs, crabs, shrimps, worms

< MOUTH

The mouth is on the underside of the stingray, allowing it to extract molluscs and crabs hidden beneath the surface of the sand. Two plates of small teeth within the mouth are used to crush the shells of its prey.



< GILL SLITS

After passing over the gills, water leaves the body through five pairs of gill slits on the underside.



< BACK SPINES

This species has relatively smooth skin, but has two parallel rows of tiny spines running down its back, as well as other scattered spines.



^ ARMED TAIL

The tail is armed with one or two sharp, barbed spines that cause physical wounds and inject venom if the ray is attacked or stepped on.

spiracle
behind eye

barbed tail

